century. According to *Tarikh-i Sistan*, the bellicosity was prolonged as most confrontations between the military presences did not result in definitive eradication of either side: in cases of victory for the Islam-affiliated forces, the Rutbil paid high indemnities in lieu of being deposed outright, which in turn perpetuated general instability in the region.[59]

Equally significant for our purposes is a discernible pattern among strengthening or newly coalescing polities in the aftermath of the Sasanian empire's *dénouement*: their emulation of the Sasanians through architectural patronage and continuity in ceremonial and ritual cultures, essentially "assert[ing] their legitimacy by placing themselves firmly in the line of past Iranian kings".[60] The sandwiching of southern Ghur between Zamindawar and Sistan(-Khurasan) could have facilitated the extension there of a "Sasanianizing" architectural culture during the late centuries of the first millennium CE.

The working conclusion I offer, then, is that Ghur's *already existing* towers and fortified structures continued to play an important role for the Shansabanis' pre-imperial ancestors as well as other Ghuris, who formed part of the complex and ever-changing nomad–urban continuum of Ghur and its contiguous regions. The Ghuris – including among them the group who would eventually identify themselves as the Shansabanis – repurposed and/or reused this inherited landscape and its built environment, especially during their winter sojourns in the *garm-sir* of southern Ghur, touching on the borders of Zamindawar and Sistan. In light of the alternative dating proposed here for central–southern Ghur's towers and other structures, it seems worthwhile to reassess the dismissive characterization of Ghuris in general as an unruly and decidedly disruptive people. A more nuanced understanding of their political and cultural milieu prior to the twelfth century is now beginning to emerge, as we bear in mind both their degrees of transhumance/nomadism, and their inheritance of a built environment largely pre-determined by their Hephthalite, Sasanian, and/or Western Turk predecessors.

During the eleventh and twelfth centuries, Ghur's location as "the buffer-zone between [the] two empires" of the Ghaznavids and Saljuqs apparently ensnared the region within the imperial wrangling and skirmishes often taking place uncomfortably close to its permeable "borders."[61] While this point of contact was admittedly a politico-military bane for the Ghuris, *architecturally* speaking it could be seen as a boon: Sasanianizing trends had already entered the region, as noted above. Furthermore, the pre-eminent imperial formations of the eleventh–twelfth centuries vied for supremacy in its environs, enabling the influx of the brick-based architectural culture emerging from farther west in Saljuq Iran (cf. Chapter 1). This identifiable set of building practices incorporated some components from their Sasanian predecessors, but essentially were coalescing as the transregional and "cosmopolitan" imperial language of a new age,